

and involves telling the same story several times from different points of view. For example, for one chapter the players might play their normal characters, then the next chapter they might portray the antagonists working against them, and then in another chapter the players might play mortal detectives trying to figure out what's behind the strange events in their town as the other two groups clash. While logistically this style can be a bit demanding, the payoff when players see things from different sets of eyes is well worth the effort.

Regardless of the style chosen, though, it is important to remember that while Storytellers may draw inspiration from all kinds of sources — books, movies, television, comics, video games, music, or what have you — certain realities require a little adjustment in tabletop roleplaying as compared to most other forms of storytelling. Perhaps most importantly, as noted in the Hero's Journey description, many conventional stories focus primarily around a single protagonist or “chosen one,” which does not translate well to gaming where all characters should be of equal importance to the overall story. So attempting to



Subplots

As the name suggests, a subplot is a secondary story arc that takes place alongside the main plot, but is not necessarily crucial to the main plot's conclusion. Most of the time a subplot is confined to one, maybe two of the characters — if it involves everyone in the group, it's probably not a subplot anymore. Classic examples of subplots include romances between two characters or a character and a supporting character, or personal storylines involving a character's mortal life away from the main events of the story (work, school, family, etc.). Some subplots may resolve in a chapter or two, while others may last the length of a story or even a chronicle.

A short story may not have room for subplots, but in a longer chronicle they are a wonderful way to flesh out characters and offer some perspective on the bigger events of the main story. It's also a good method for exploring areas that the player finds interesting about her character or the world of the story, but which are too far removed to devote time to during a regular chapter. Players can also experiment a bit in subplots without worrying about derailing the main storyline.

A subplot need not even take up time during a chapter; if the Storyteller and the player agree, subplots can be handled by conversation or email during downtime, sometimes with just roleplaying and little to no dice rolling. As a rule of thumb, in a longer chronicle it's a good idea for each character to have a subplot of some kind every story, just to give the player a chance to explore other aspects of his character that might not be relevant to or explored in the main arc.



model a chronicle after a film that featured a single heroine, for instance, would require shifting different story elements and roles to spread them out across multiple characters so that everyone is central to the story.

Chronicle

A chronicle is the name given to an ongoing game that lasts for one or more stories. A chronicle typically revolves around a single group of player characters, though larger or more ambitious groups might have multiple teams of characters featured during a chronicle. There are many advantages to running a chronicle, chief among them being the ability to build really engaging, well-developed, in-depth fiction as group. With a number of chapters and sometimes even multiple stories at her disposal, a Storyteller can take time to craft a complex, nuanced narrative that unfolds at a pace of her choosing, rather than feeling rushed to wrap everything up in a chapter or two.

Planning a long-running chronicle is perhaps best compared to writing a trilogy of novels or constructing a multi-film franchise. Each story in the chronicle is equivalent to an individual book or movie in the sequence — it should tell a tale that is satisfying on its own, but it can also build toward an overall conclusion that is greater than the sum of the individual installments. One common way to do this is to introduce an ongoing antagonist that is simply too powerful for the characters to confront directly, at least early on, leading the players to spend multiple stories exploring how best to overcome this dire enemy, while enduring the villain's increasingly dangerous attentions as they become more and more of a threat.

Tolkien's *Lord of the Rings* cycle is a good example of this type of chronicle design structure, as each book in the sequence tells a satisfying tale in its own right, but together they build toward an epic conclusion that ties all the books together and topples a seemingly insurmountable villain. Another solid design example would be the different “phases” of the Marvel Cinematic Universe, where individual movies tell their own stories but also weave together common elements in order to set the stage for a grand climax at the end of the phase. The television series *The Wire* is another role model; a Storyteller could look at it as a chronicle exploring crime in a modern city, with each season of the show serving as a story that illustrates the impact in a different part of the city.

Like stories, there are variations on chronicle structures. For example, there is the “anthology” style, which is a type of chronicle where a certain element remains the same across every story while other things change around it. This element can be as vague as a theme, like stories all based on the notion “what is lost always returns,” or it can be more specific, like a chronicle where each story is based on a different time period in the history of a single freehold. Typically, the players make different characters for each story in an anthology chronicle, though sometimes they may have connections to previous characters, such as being the descendants of an earlier time, the opposing faction of a previous story, and so on.